

AN EVIDENCE-LED PARANORMAL DOCUMENTARY

SWEET SPRINGS THE NAME THAT REMAINED

History, memory, and the making of a West Virginia haunting

Gap Mills / Sweet Springs, Monroe County, West Virginia

Written from the Paranormal Investigator factual source packet

Research current through September 8, 2026

Opening Hook

The water reaches the surface at seventy-three degrees Fahrenheit. It carries iron and carbon dioxide from beneath Peters Mountain, feeding a spring that once promised health, society, and temporary escape. Above it stands a monumental brick hotel with columned porticos: too large to disappear into the landscape, too old to belong entirely to the present.

At different moments, people came to this place to recover, to be entertained, to receive treatment, or simply to live out their final years with care. The rooms changed with them. Resort chambers became offices and medical spaces. New wings grew behind antebellum brickwork. Generations crossed the floors, then left the buildings quiet enough for every small sound to acquire a possible meaning.

Modern television knows the property by a sharper name: Sweet Springs Sanitarium. The words suggest a vast institution, decades of sickness, and corridors filled with uncounted dead. Investigators have reported voices, screams, footsteps, shadow figures, slamming doors, and the touch of an unseen hand. Streaming descriptions claim that hundreds died here. Other retellings raise the toll even higher.

The records tell a stranger story. The sanitarium appears to have lasted little more than a year.

Introduction

Sweet Springs lies in eastern Monroe County, West Virginia, close to the Virginia border. Modern directories often place it under Gap Mills, while historic records call the community Sweet Springs and the resort Old Sweet. The name matters because several nearby mineral resorts have similar titles. Sweet Chalybeate Springs lies across the state line, while Red Sulphur Springs and Salt Sulphur Springs belong to the same wider resort landscape. Their histories, tragedies, and legends are easily confused when repeated without precise locations.

The surviving complex at Sweet Springs is real, extensive, and historically important. Its National Register nomination covers an approximately eight-and-a-half-acre core containing the Jefferson Building, the Ball Building, four brick guest houses, Elbow Row cottage, and a later bathhouse. Its history reaches into the first decades of American resort culture, the slave economy of antebellum Virginia, the Civil War, twentieth-century public medicine, institutional elder care, and modern preservation.

Its paranormal reputation is much younger. The publicly traceable accounts found for the investigation begin in the modern ghost-hunting era, particularly after private overnight investigations were advertised in 2018 and television productions brought the property to a national audience. No dated firsthand account was located from a resort guest, tuberculosis patient, Rowan Home resident, or employee describing a haunting during the years when those institutions operated.

THE CENTRAL QUESTION What remains when the documented history of Sweet Springs is separated from the story created around the word sanitarium?

Chapter 1

The Water and the House

The recorded history begins with land and water. In 1774 the Lewis family received patents around the springs. William Lewis, a Revolutionary War veteran, moved there in 1783 and began developing the mineral water as a commercial resort. By the 1790s surviving accounts describe an active establishment that could accommodate about fifty patrons in log cabins. The first hotel is traditionally dated to 1792.

The springs offered more than bathing. For a period beginning in 1795, a Virginia district court serving Botetourt, Greenbrier, Kanawha, and Montgomery counties met at Sweet Springs. Sources disagree about the closing year: one gives 1807, while the National Register history extends the court's presence to 1817. The difference does not change the broader picture. Before there was a great brick hotel, Sweet Springs was already a resort, gathering place, and temporary seat of law.

Its heyday came between 1820 and the Civil War. In the 1830s, the present main hotel rose in a Jeffersonian style: a long brick facade organized around monumental columned porticos. Later histories often turned architectural influence into authorship and credited Thomas Jefferson himself. The National Register researcher rejected that conclusion. The surviving building was constructed after Jefferson died in 1826. It may have been designed by a person familiar with his work, often identified in later scholarship as William B. Phillips, but the record does not support Jefferson as the architect.

Jefferson did know of the springs. A 1791 letter referred to a woman's proposed trip there for her health. Knowledge, influence, and authorship are three different claims. At Sweet Springs, popular history gradually compressed them into one.

The Resort World

Sweet Springs belonged to a network of mineral resorts through which affluent visitors travelled during the summer season. Guests came for the water, but also for the company: meals, games, dancing, conversation, and the visibility of belonging to fashionable society. Pierce and Fillmore appear in the surviving register, and Henry Clay sent a letter from the resort. A longer list of celebrated visitors circulates through later histories, including George and Martha Washington, Lafayette, John Marshall,

Patrick Henry, James and Dolley Madison, Robert E. Lee, and Jerome Bonaparte. The National Register nomination cautions that evidence for many prominent early guests is scant.

One legend is easier to trace. Jerome Bonaparte was said to have courted or married at Sweet Springs. The National Register researcher concluded that the tradition grew from the filming of the motion picture *Glorious Betsy* on the property. Cinema did not merely record the building; it gave the building a memory.

The resort's polished public life rested on labor largely absent from its glamorous accounts. Sweet Springs operated within antebellum Virginia's system of slavery. Architectural histories identify dwellings for enslaved workers, and the daily functioning of a resort required construction, agriculture, cooking, cleaning, maintenance, transport, and personal service. The accessible record gives far more space to wealthy guests than to the people whose coerced labor sustained their comfort. Their missing names are part of the site's history, not an invitation to assign them invented supernatural roles.

Financial trouble changed ownership in 1852. Allen T. Caperton, Oliver Beirne, and their associates advanced an ambitious semicircular plan for the grounds. A second large building and five cottages followed in 1857, though only part of the complete design became reality. When Union forces under General David Hunter entered the area in June 1864, they camped near the resort. No record shows that they damaged the complex.

After the war, Sweet Springs reopened into a less forgiving economy. Its distance from direct rail service placed it at a disadvantage against resorts such as White Sulphur Springs. The Lewis family returned between 1902 and 1920, but a succession of owners failed to restore the old prosperity. The property entered receivership in 1930.

Fifteen Months

The building's next role produced the name that now dominates its identity. In 1941 the property was acquired for conversion into a tuberculosis institution. The renovation was substantial. The state-era historical record describes changes to the Jefferson Building's interior for offices and medical needs and the addition of a rear wing.

A contemporary newspaper dated January 5, 1942, reported that the Old Sweet Springs tuberculosis sanatorium had received its first patients during the previous week. Another report in March 1943 described fourteen ambulances mobilized to transfer patients away from the facility. The Monroe County Historical Society also dates the sanatorium's closure to 1943.

Those records confine the operation to approximately fifteen months. Some later histories extend it through 1945, perhaps because that was the year the complex reopened under its next name. Even the

longer version allows only three years. Neither supports the familiar claim that Sweet Springs treated tuberculosis patients for decades.

The distinction is more than a correction of dates. Tuberculosis hospitals carried real suffering, uncertainty, and death. Inflating their history into an invented mass tragedy turns patients into scenery and makes it harder to ask what actually happened to them. No patient register, mortality ledger, death-certificate study, or cemetery survey was produced in the public sources used to support claims that hundreds, or more than a thousand people, died at Sweet Springs.

The Rowan Years

In 1945 the complex opened as the Andrew S. Rowan Memorial Home for older residents. This was the property's longest institutional chapter. For nearly half a century, people lived there while employees worked in its offices, kitchens, chapel, wards, and later additions. Major renovations between 1972 and 1975 introduced modern residential wings while preserving much of the historic exterior.

The National Register of Historic Places recognized Old Sweet Springs in 1970. Its nomination praised the complex not as a sanitarium, but as one of America's oldest mineral-water resorts and an unusually intact reflection of nineteenth-century resort life.

The Rowan Home closed in 1991 according to state reference sources, although some later accounts give 1993. A proposed substance-abuse rehabilitation center did not materialize. Private sales followed. Preservation authorities identified the vacant complex as endangered in 2005, with the bathhouse in a state of collapse. In November 2015 Ashby Berkley bought the property and its water-bottling equipment at auction for \$560,000. Restoration work, fundraising, tours, paranormal rentals, and public events followed intermittently.

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By then, the old resort had acquired another use. It had become a place where visitors came not to take the water, but to listen to the building after dark.

Chapter 2

The Birth of the Legend

A continuous haunting tradition should leave traces: a dated newspaper item, an employee recollection, a resident's letter, a memoir, or even a clearly attributed local account. None appeared in the historical sources reviewed for this documentary. The archives establish centuries of use, but they do not establish centuries of ghost reports.

The first securely dated public marker located in the source packet arrives in October 2018. A representative of Sweet Springs announced that the property would accept private paranormal investigations beginning that November. Groups of up to ten could rent the site for an eighteen-hour session. Only one team would be booked at a time, although staff members or contractors might still be working in the building.

That final condition is easy to overlook. It also matters. A distant footstep, voice, scrape, or door movement cannot be classified as unexplained unless every person and active work area is logged. The booking arrangement reduced one source of interference by separating investigative groups, but it did not create a sealed environment.

Television supplied the next stage. Paranormal Lockdown opened its third season at Old Sweet Springs in December 2018. Destination Fear followed in 2019. Paranormal Encounters released an episode that same year, describing the property as a former resort, tuberculosis hospital, and nursing home that had witnessed hundreds of deaths. The Ghost Finders later devoted two episodes to the location, and other streaming and online productions followed.

Each retelling pushed the property toward the identity carried by its new name. Two centuries of resort history narrowed into a medical corridor. A tuberculosis institution that operated for roughly fifteen months became one of the oldest sanitariums in the country. A home for older residents became a generalized source of spirits. Sparse mortality evidence became hundreds of deaths.

The shift did not require deliberate deception. Repetition can perform the work on its own. A venue description becomes a television introduction. The introduction becomes a streaming synopsis. The synopsis is copied into a travel page, where it appears to corroborate the first account. Several publications may then repeat the same unsupported number, creating the appearance of independent agreement.

EARLIEST TRACEABLE PARANORMAL ERA The reviewed record supports a modern, commercially visible haunting reputation beginning no later than 2018. It does not establish when the first private experience occurred.

The Figures Given Names

Once the haunted identity was established, its population grew. Visitors spoke of figures in hospital gowns. A woman in white appeared near the spring or in corridors. A shadow crossed a doorway. Recent social-media retellings introduced a little girl called Allie, sometimes described as the daughter of a patient. Television language invoked a dark or demonic presence.

None of these figures has been connected to a verified individual in the site's history. No patient record establishes Allie. No dated encounter identifies the woman in white. No historical event supplies a documented curse. The figures belong to folklore as the evidence currently stands.

This does not mean that every witness invented an experience. A person may sincerely see a human form in low light or hear a voice in an ambiguous recording. The problem begins when perception becomes biography. A silhouette becomes a patient; a radio fragment becomes a child's name; a cold draft becomes proof of a death that the record never documented.

Chapter 3

Reported Encounters

The best-known reported encounters come from Paranormal Lockdown. Nick Groff and Katrina Weidman remained at the property for an extended investigation centered on the old building and spring. Groff reported feeling a hand grab his leg. The team interpreted one sound as a voice saying 'not safe' and another as 'help me.' They also recorded a noise compared to a chair being dragged.

These events were documented within a produced television program. The distinction is important. The broadcast shows that investigators reported and recorded something; it does not provide continuous access to the complete environment. Viewers cannot reconstruct every person's position, every radio transmission, every staff movement, or every discarded segment. Even the investigators separated their material into subjective and objective categories, while a contemporary Washington Post review described the methods as questionable.

Destination Fear approached Sweet Springs through a format built around isolation and the limits of fear. Its episode publicized apparent screams, chanting, and a voice disturbing enough to push an investigator toward panic. Those reactions are part of the record. So is the editorial structure surrounding them: participants arrive knowing the location's reputation, enter darkness expecting activity, and experience ambiguous sounds under sustained emotional pressure.

A different kind of testimony appeared in 2024. Travel writer Jody Arneson published a first-person account of a group investigation. The article describes a shadow figure encountered shortly after entry, another human-shaped darkness noticed later in a photograph, knocks, bangs, apparent door slams, and rustling from rooms while the writer was apart from the others. It also reports cold areas and voices associated with the property.

This account has useful specificity: the writer distinguishes immediate perceptions from an image interpreted afterward and admits that debris made part of the spring area unsafe to investigate. Yet the article presents no original-resolution photograph, timestamps, sensor logs, or continuous record of the group's positions. Its historical section also repeats claims contradicted by stronger records, including decades of tuberculosis treatment and Jefferson's involvement in the building. The witness account remains valid as testimony, but the accompanying interpretation cannot inherit historical reliability from it.

The Ghost Guild records an investigation conducted on June 7, 2020. Its public page says that data is being processed for publication, but no results appear there. This is a useful negative finding. An

investigation occurred; publicly reviewable evidence did not follow. The absence should not be filled by inference.

Patterns in the Reports

Across productions and visitor accounts, several categories recur: voices, footsteps, knocks, dragging sounds, shadow figures, doors moving, and occasional physical contact. Recurrence can justify describing these as multiple reports. It cannot establish a common cause. The accounts occurred at different times under different conditions, and later investigators usually knew what earlier teams had claimed.

The named entities are less stable than the sounds. The woman in white and the girl called Allie lack traceable historical identities. Apparitions in hospital gowns fit the building's public image but sit awkwardly beside the short medical chronology. A supposed electroshock room appears in recent social-media descriptions even though the verified history identifies a tuberculosis facility and an elder-care home, not a psychiatric hospital. No architectural plan, equipment inventory, or treatment record in the source packet supports electroconvulsive therapy at Sweet Springs.

The broad claims are therefore the most defensible: people have reported hearing and seeing things they could not immediately identify. The narrow claims, which assign a voice to a child, a silhouette to a patient, or a sensation to a demon, rest on additional assumptions not established by the evidence.

Chapter 4

Inside the Investigation

Paranormal investigation often begins with an honest question and a difficult environment. Sweet Springs magnifies both. It contains long corridors, hard masonry surfaces, stairwells, altered interiors, old doors, chimneys, voids, attached wings, and detached structures. A quiet building of that scale is not acoustically empty. It collects distant activity and delivers it without context.

The most dramatic audio evidence has often come through electronic voice phenomena or radio-sweep devices. Digital recorders can capture distant speech, handling noise, insects, wildlife, electrical interference, and compression artifacts. A radio-sweep device adds fragments of commercial transmissions by design. When an investigator asks a question and hears a syllable that resembles an answer, timing gives the fragment meaning before its source is known.

Laboratory research on auditory pareidolia offers a relevant general mechanism. Participants primed to expect paranormal voices are more likely to report words in ambiguous recordings. That does not prove that any particular Sweet Springs recording is misperceived. It explains why an evidential recording must be tested blind, without telling listeners what phrase they are expected to hear.

The visual reports face a similar difficulty. In weak or infrared illumination, door frames, damaged plaster, equipment shadows, reflective surfaces, moving vegetation, and other people can form incomplete patterns. The mind completes them rapidly. A photograph recognized as an apparition only during later review is especially vulnerable to hindsight because the viewer can examine noise and shadow until a figure emerges.

The building itself supplies other candidate mechanisms. Temperature changes move wood, metal, pipes, roofs, and doors. Pressure differences can swing an unsecured door. Bats, birds, and small mammals occupy neglected structures and can produce sounds disproportionate to their size. Research on bats confirms that buildings commonly serve as roosts, shelters, and hibernation sites. Localized drafts and thermal gradients around chimneys, broken seals, masonry openings, stairwells, and additions can produce the cold areas investigators associate with a presence.

These mechanisms are possibilities, not solved cases. No site-specific acoustic model, wildlife survey, continuous thermal map, or structural-noise test was published with the major paranormal claims. A disciplined conventional explanation must obey the same rule as a paranormal one: it cannot be declared proven merely because it is plausible.

What Strong Evidence Would Require

A stronger investigation would begin before darkness. Researchers would map the buildings, identify active mechanical systems, inspect doors and pressure paths, document animal access, and obtain a complete list of staff, contractors, and nearby activity. Synchronized cameras and recorders would cover investigators as well as supposed hotspots. Every spoken word and movement would be logged.

Audio clips would be preserved from original files with metadata intact. Independent listeners would first transcribe them without being told the proposed words. Photographs would be released at original resolution with exposure information and images taken immediately before and after. Temperature claims would be compared against fixed sensors and exterior weather. Equipment failures would be tested under repeatable conditions instead of treated as communication by default.

Most important, historical identities would be assigned only after documentary confirmation. A name produced through a radio fragment is not evidence that a person with that name lived or died there. A cemetery is not a catalogue of ghosts. The history and the experiment must remain independent until evidence joins them.

Chapter 5

Separating Fact from Folklore

What survives scrutiny at Sweet Springs is substantial. The mineral resort operated by the 1790s. The great hotel belongs to the Jeffersonian architectural tradition, although Jefferson almost certainly did not design it. The property passed through war, financial decline, public medicine, elder care, abandonment, private sale, and preservation. Enslaved people formed part of the labor system that made antebellum resort life possible. Tuberculosis patients arrived around the end of 1941, and transfers out were reported in March 1943. The Andrew S. Rowan Memorial Home then occupied the complex for decades.

The paranormal record supports a different set of conclusions. Multiple investigators have reported voices, footsteps, knocks, moving doors, and shadow-like forms. Groff reported apparent physical contact. Arneson described a shadow photograph and sounds from apparently empty rooms. These are traceable accounts of experiences. They are not independently replicated demonstrations of spirits.

The woman in white, Allie, a demonic presence, the electroshock room, and a vast TB death toll do not survive at the same evidential level. Their sources are recent retellings, entertainment descriptions, or unattributed claims. Some directly conflict with the chronology. Others remain possible only in the broadest sense, with no documentation connecting them to Sweet Springs.

The most consequential folklore is the name itself. 'Sweet Springs Sanitarium' is not false: the property was used as a sanatorium. But the name rearranges proportion. It allows a short chapter to eclipse the resort that shaped the architecture and the elder-care home that occupied it far longer. Once the building is introduced as a sanitarium, every long corridor becomes a ward, every room a patient's room, and every sound a possible remnant of treatment. The label performs part of the haunting before an investigation begins.

The documented suffering does not need exaggeration. Tuberculosis patients faced a dangerous disease. Elderly residents lived and died within an institution that became their home. Enslaved workers built and maintained a culture of luxury from which they were excluded. Those histories deserve records, names, and context. Converting them into an interchangeable population of ghosts makes the story less accurate and less human.

At the same time, dismissing every witness would outrun the evidence in the opposite direction. The source packet does not explain each knock, voice, shadow, or sensation. Some experiences may have ordinary causes that were never identified. Some recordings are too incomplete to judge. Others remain

private or unpublished. Unexplained is a description of the present state of knowledge. It is not a synonym for supernatural, but neither is it a confession of fraud.

Conclusion

The spring continues to rise at the foot of the mountain. Around it stands a building that has repeatedly been asked to promise something: health, status, treatment, shelter, restoration, proof of life after death.

Sweet Springs has answered some of those requests through records. The records preserve land patents, resort accounts, court sessions, architectural changes, ownership transfers, newspaper notices, state care, and national recognition. They also correct the most dramatic version of the modern legend. The sanitarium was brief. The death toll is undocumented. The famous architect is improbable. The named spirits have no verified biographies.

What remains is quieter and more difficult. People entered the building and reported that something answered them. A voice seemed to say help me. A hand seemed to close around a leg. A dark shape seemed to occupy a room. None of those experiences can be recovered in full from a television edit, a compressed photograph, or a retrospective article. They remain testimony: worth recording, insufficient for certainty.

The deepest haunting at Sweet Springs may therefore be the tension between the place and the name imposed upon it. The place contains more than two centuries of American history. The name asks us to see only illness and death.

The building has not yielded proof of ghosts. It has revealed how readily history can be narrowed until folklore fits inside it. And when the spring, the resort, the workers, the patients, and the residents are restored to view, Sweet Springs becomes more mysterious, not less: a place where the past is genuinely present, even when the dead cannot be shown to be.

Source Map

This documentary treats the Paranormal Investigator report as a closed factual packet. The sources below retain the packet's evidence hierarchy. Official and contemporary records establish the historical chronology; paranormal programs and eyewitness pages document claims rather than their supernatural interpretation.

Primary and official sources

- [National Register of Historic Places nomination: Old Sweet Springs](#)
- [West Virginia Encyclopedia: Sweet Springs](#)
- [Library of Congress, Historic American Buildings Survey: Sweet Springs](#)
- [Covington Virginian, January 5, 1942: first TB patients](#)
- [Covington Virginian, March 18, 1943: transfer of TB patients](#)

Historical scholarship and local history

- [Monroe County Historical Society: Springs Resorts of Monroe County](#)
- [Sweet Springs historical summary](#)

Reputable journalism

- [The Washington Post review of Paranormal Lockdown](#)
- [West Virginia Daily News: 2024 restoration and events update](#)

Eyewitness and investigation records

- [The Ghost Guild investigation record, June 7, 2020](#)
- [MidAtlantic Daytrips first-person investigation account, 2024](#)
- [2018 private-investigation announcement preserved at West Virginia Executive](#)

Paranormal media

- [Destination Fear: Sweet Springs Sanitarium](#)
- [Sweet Springs paranormal-program archive](#)

Scientific context

- [Nees and Phillips: auditory pareidolia and contextual priming](#)
- [French et al.: the Haunt room experiment](#)

- [Voigt et al.: bats and buildings](#)

Editorial Note

Current access to Sweet Springs could not be confirmed for September 2026. Recent reporting documents intermittent tours, events, and paranormal rentals, but the property is privately controlled and under restoration. Visitors should obtain direct permission and current safety instructions before entering. Earlier availability does not imply present public access.